

Appendix: The Philologos

(The fire was burning low, just enough to throw faces into light — bright one moment, shadowed the next. Someone had pressed a mug of hot cider into my hands, and I was rolling the old ring on my finger, aware in that peculiar way that this would have been one of the moments. The Aureom. Already golden, even before I'd stepped into tomorrow.

Samuel sat across from me, elbows on his knees, the flames caught in the glass of his spectacles. Eliot leaned back on a log beside him, his scarf loose, looking like he could either speak for an hour or fall silent for the rest of the night. The flames breathe in their slow rhythm, throwing light up against the stone wall of the longhouse. A kettle murmurs somewhere in the dark. Around the fire, blankets are pulled tighter; cups are cradled.)

Samuel Ashcombe:

So, Jack—this is the end of your time among us. How goes the experiment?

Jack Stone:

It's been good. Quieter than London, obviously. The pace here... it feels like it stretches out the days.

Eliot Ashton *(grinning)*:

That's one way to put it. We'd probably say we're just slow to get things done.

Jack:

It doesn't feel like slowness. More like—things aren't in such a rush to finish. Even the work days, you all seem to take your time. There's space for a bit of talking, a bit of looking around.

Samuel:

Sounds romanticised to me. But that's why you're here, isn't it? To see if life like this can fit into your... project.

Jack:

I suppose so. I wanted to see what it's like for people to live together without all the usual layers—offices, commutes, city noise. I'm used to London, where everything's clipped and to the point. Here, people let moments breathe a bit more.

Eliot:

And you think that changes the way we speak?

Jack:

Yeah. You've already got a way of talking that's... I don't know, it carries a bit more space. I'm just wondering if we can make more of that. Give it some shape without making it artificial.

Samuel:

Shape it how?

Jack:

By paying attention to how we talk to each other. Making sure our words match what we want this place to feel like. What reality you want it to look like.

Eliot:

Then you've got a good night for it. Fire, tea, vodka, and no one's going anywhere.

Samuel:

So here's the thing, Jack—you've landed here right in the middle of a bigger shift. Thorne's in custody, Manchester's DAOs are leaderless, and the north's not in the mood to keep playing along with London's rules.

Jack:

I've heard.

Eliot:

It's more than that. Since Thorne got pulled in, people have been... freer, I suppose, to say outright what they were hinting at before. The old idea of parliamentary sovereignty? Nobody here really buys it anymore. We're governing ourselves through networks, councils, and cooperatives—and the south just calls it "temporary arrangements."

Samuel:

Temporary's been two years now. And every month, Westminster sends another delegation up to "integrate" us back into the fold.

Jack:

And you think that's impossible now?

Eliot:

Not impossible. Just... irrelevant. We've got our own decision systems, our own way of moving resources. Even our own currency. Why would we hand that back to people who never really understood what we were building?

Samuel:

Exactly. The post-state order isn't a theory anymore—it's practice. What we've been living here in Bamford, in Sheffield, in the Peaks—it's proof you don't need a parliament to run a society. We don't need to declare anything, we just turn our backs on all that we don't need.

Jack:

But you've still got disputes, right? Borders, agreements, rules—just like anywhere else.

Eliot:

Sure. But we settle them in the open. No party lines, no five-year election cycles. We decide when the thing needs deciding, and everyone who's affected gets a say. It's all about consensus models.

Samuel:

Which is where your angle comes in, Jack. If we're making something new, the language we use to talk about it matters. You get that better than most.

Jack:

I get that words can steer the thing without anyone noticing they've been steered. If the north's pulling away, you're going to need ways of talking about it that make sense to people here—and don't just mirror the old London tone.

Eliot:

And that's exactly why you're by this fire instead of in some lecture hall.

Jack:

If the state's power is fading—if the north's going its own way—what's going to hold it together? We've seen this before. Not in politics, but in religion.

Eliot:

You're talking about Protestantism again?

Jack:

Back when it was at its height, it wasn't a crown or a parliament binding the towns and villages. It was the logos. Preached, printed, memorised. A kind of authority no king could fully control.

Eliot:

And you're saying language could do that now.

Jack:

It already does, just in thinner form. Think about the slogans, the hashtags—people repeat them like hymns. But that's noise. If we had a shared way of speaking about the world—about our politics, our place, our future—it could carry the same weight Protestantism did then.

Eliot:

The difference being, there's no church to guard it. No bishops to issue corrections.

Jack:

Which is the strength of it, and the danger. If the thing catches, it lives in the mouths of ordinary people. But it also means you can't pull it back once it spreads.

Samuel:

That's what I want you to think about. If we make a language that can bind a society, we also give it a kind of authority outside of councils or votes. That's not far from creating a new church, Jack.

Jack:

Except this one wouldn't be built around belief in the same creed—it'd be built around the way we speak about life together. Shared phrases, shared turns of thought. Enough to make someone in Leeds and someone here in Bamford feel they're part of the same living thing, even if they've never met.

Eliot:

Like the hymns again—same words sung in a hundred places, so you know you belong before you've even walked in.

Jack:

Right. Except ours wouldn't be hymns—it'd be the everyday ways of talking about fairness, decision-making, even beauty. If we get that tone right, you don't need a central parliament. The speech itself becomes the structure.

Samuel *(with a nod):*

And once that's in place, it's harder for anyone—London, Westminster, whoever—to pull us back under.

Jack:

Yes. But remember—once you set it loose, it's not yours anymore. It belongs to whoever speaks it.

(A few murmurs around the fire. Someone pours more tea. The circle leans in a little closer.)

Eliot:

So if language can bind people like that, the next question's obvious—what happens when someone starts shaping that language on purpose?

Samuel (*glancing at Jack*):

You mean when a philologist sits down and encodes the thing so it steers reality toward their theory? That's not just binding—it's authoring the whole framework people think inside. That's quite the power.

Jack:

It's the same kind of power coders have had for decades. Cypherpunks write code to shape the systems we live in—money, privacy, communication. I just work in the human layer. Same principle.

Eliot:

Except code runs on machines. What you're talking about runs in people's heads.

Jack:

Exactly. Which means it's more fragile—and harder to erase once it's out there. You get a few key phrases lodged in the public's everyday speech, you shift the frame of what feels normal, fair, even possible.

Samuel:

That's politics without looking like politics.

Jack:

It's culture. But culture can be upstream of politics. If you make a way of speaking that makes certain kinds of decisions feel natural and others feel alien, you've already shaped the field before a vote's even cast.

Eliot:

And you think that can be done deliberately?

Jack:

It's always being done. Advertisers do it, governments do it. I'm just saying we can do it openly, for our own purposes, and with a better aim than shifting products.

Samuel:

Which brings us back to my point—once you've done it, you've let something loose that can't easily be pulled back.

Jack:

True. But I'd rather we were the ones writing it than waiting for someone else to drop theirs into our mouths.

(A few people in the circle murmur agreement; the fire shifts, spitting a bright spark into the dark.)

Samuel:

You see the risk, don't you? Craft a new form of language, you've crafted a new form of power. And power, Eliot, has a habit of shaping itself into control—whether it wears robes or jeans.

Eliot:

I get it. But you're saying Jack's at the centre it and he's going to use it for tyrannical purposes?

Samuel:

Why not? The philologist becomes the philosopher, the philosopher becomes the lawgiver, the lawgiver becomes—well, history's clear enough—tyrant. You start encoding reality in a new tongue, rather than law, and you're composing a new reality for the world to walk into.

Jack:

That's not where I'm going with this. What I'm thinking about isn't control—it's sovereignty. Linguistic sovereignty.

Samuel:

Meaning?

Jack:

Meaning, if we push English—push *language*—beyond the limits it's stuck in now, we don't lock people into a version of reality. We give them the means to shape their own. The point isn't to hand everyone the same script. It's to give them a bigger stage, more tools, more colours.

Eliot:

So you're saying a stronger, more flexible language makes people less dependent on any single authority.

Jack:

Exactly. If someone can describe their life in richer, more exact ways, they're not as easy to box in. The danger isn't in having too much language—it's in having too little. That's when people get trapped inside slogans they didn't write.

Samuel:

Still sounds like you're putting a lot of faith in the idea that a sovereign individual will use that freedom well.

Jack:

I am. Because the alternative is to keep language narrow, safe, and owned by whoever happens to hold the microphone. I'd rather see it opened up—even if that means some will use it in ways I wouldn't.

Eliot:

Alright, but here's the rub. If everyone's got the freedom to make their own reality through language, how do we stop it splintering? One person's poetry becomes another's gibberish. You're not just pushing English—you're making a hundred different Englishes.

Samuel:

And the moment there's no shared ground, it's not cohesion anymore. It's Babel.

Eliot:

Exactly. Feels a bit like the myth—people reaching upward, building their own towers of speech, until no one understands anyone else.

Jack:

I'm not against towers. But they need to be built on the same bedrock. Think of it less as one language breaking apart, more as a set of high registers built on a common base. To speak over the low grass.

Eliot:

High registers?

Jack:

Yeah. You could have *Aesthetic English*—built for beauty and ceremony. *Hedonistic English*—playful, lush, pushing pleasure into the sentence. *Aristocratic English*—polished, deliberate, carrying the weight of considered judgment. They're different modes, but they all speak to the same underlying structure.

Samuel:

So, people can choose the mode that fits the moment, but they still understand each other.

Jack:

Exactly. You get the freedom to shape your own expression without losing the thread that ties us together. The problem with the Babel myth wasn't that people reached too high—it's that they lost the bridge between their heights.

Eliot:

And you think you can build that bridge?

Jack:

Not me alone. But if we treat language as shared code, like a repository—something we all tend and expand together—then yeah, I think we can make a bridge that still lets the towers rise.

(The fire leans low for a moment, the embers glowing like the coals of an argument that's not yet burned out.)

Samuel:

I can see those registers catching on, Jack. But you realise they could turn into badges of class, right? Like accents used to be. You start speaking in Aristocratic English and people will hear a power move whether you meant it or not.

Jack:

That's why I keep saying—it's not really about swapping the words. It's about shifting the register. Changing the grammar, the tense, the rhythm of how you say something. That's harder to fake as just a badge, because it's about how you *think* the sentence into being.

Eliot:

Alright—show us.

Jack *(nodding, warming his hands over the fire):*

Alright. Let's take something simple. Say: *We sat under the old tree until the light faded.*

First—**Aesthetic English:**

We lingered beneath the old tree, the day folding itself into a copper hush, our silence stitched with the slow fall of light.

Second—**Hedonistic English:**

We sprawled under the old tree, warm skin against rough bark, drinking the last of the day as the sky poured itself over us.

Third—**Aristocratic English:**

We remained beneath the venerable tree until the hour's light had withdrawn, our quiet kept in the dignity of its retreat.

Eliot:

Same bones, three completely different people speaking.

Jack:

Exactly. The meaning's stable—you can still picture it—but the register shifts the tone, the mood, the whole stance toward the moment. That's where the real shaping power lies.

Samuel:

And if people learn to move between them, they carry more than one way of thinking in their heads.

Jack:

Which is the point. It's not about locking anyone into a tower—it's about giving them more rooms to walk into.

(A couple of heads nod around the fire; the kettle hisses softly as if agreeing.)

Eliot:

So let's say people here actually take this on—learn the registers, move between them. What does that get us beyond prettier sentences?

Jack:

It's not just prettiness. It's sovereignty. If you can choose your register, you choose your stance toward the world. You're not trapped in one tone, one way of naming things. That freedom changes how you experience reality.

Samuel:

Experience it—or shape it?

Jack:

Both. The way you speak about something frames it. If a crowd describes the same event in the same rhythm, same tense, same structure, they're building a shared version of it. But if they know how to shift cadence—slow it, heighten it, fold time into it—they can see the same event in more than one light.

Eliot:

So we'd end up living in a kind of shifting linguistic reality—where meaning moves with the register.

Jack:

Exactly. Picture a meeting in Sheffield. The first half's in a plain civic register—decisions, votes, agreements. Then, when it comes to the part everyone needs to *feel*—a remembrance, a binding promise—they slip into a slower cadence, let the grammar bend into something more like Aesthetic English. The change in the language changes the room.

Samuel:

You'd make cadence itself a political tool.

Jack:

A cultural one. Politics comes and goes—culture sets the deep rhythms. If we can make those

rhythms flexible, people learn to steer their own perception. You can't have true sovereignty without that.

Eliot:

And you think people could pick this up? It's not exactly how they teach English in school.

Jack:

They could—because it's not about memorising rules. It's about learning to listen to the pace of your own thought, then matching the language to it. Once you've felt the shift, you can't unhear it.

Samuel:

So in your model, the sovereign person isn't just someone who casts a vote or runs their own affairs—it's someone who can choose the language reality they stand inside at any given moment.

Jack:

That's it. You own your words, you own the frame you live in.

Samuel:

There's something in what you're saying, Jack, that sounds almost... theatrical. This shifting of cadences—register to register—it's not just communication, it's performance.

Eliot:

Yeah. Like every time you change the register, you're stepping into a role. Which means it's not just telling the truth—it could be bending it.

Jack:

That's fair. It is performative. Every change is a choice, and every choice leans the scene one way or another. You slow the cadence, you bring a hush—people remember the moment as solemn, even if it wasn't. You sharpen the grammar, make it tight and declarative—you turn a loose thought into a fact.

Samuel:

So you're saying language becomes a deliberate act of reality creation.

Jack:

Exactly. And with that comes the shadow side—reality distortion. The same tools that can deepen meaning can tilt it, warp it, exaggerate it. You can make something small feel monumental, or strip the life out of something vivid until it sounds like a technicality.

Eliot:

And you think that's safe?

Jack:

It's not safe. But nothing worth having is. The point isn't to pretend we can take distortion out of human speech—it's to give people the awareness and skill to use it consciously. Then they can tell when it's being done to them.

Samuel:

So the shift isn't just a style change—it's an exercise of agency. A signal that says: "I'm choosing the frame, and I want you to notice."

Jack:

Right. A sovereign speaker knows when they're building reality and when they're bending it. The danger is when people don't even realise they're doing either.

Eliot:

Alright, let's bring this back to the ground. Say the north keeps pulling away from Westminster, building its own ways of running things. How does this language-shifting actually work in practice? You're not just talking about poetry at the market square, are you?

Jack:

No. I'm talking about the texture of decision-making. Picture a meeting in Sheffield—half traders, half co-op reps, some folks from the communes. You start in plain speech for facts and figures. Then, when you reach the proposals that affect how people feel about the city—its identity, its direction—you shift the register. You move into a cadence that carries weight. The change tells everyone: this part is binding.

Samuel:

So it's signalling through form. The register marks the moment as more than administrative—it makes it ceremonial.

Eliot:

And in doing that, you're shaping reality. You're saying: "this is the part that matters" before anyone's even voted.

Jack:

Exactly. You use language as a frame for reality, so that decisions aren't just written in minutes—they're felt. That way the binding moments carry across different towns and communes, even if they've never met.

Samuel:

You realise that's governance. Not in the old parliamentary sense, but in the sense of creating the shared fabric that holds a political order together.

Eliot:

And it could be just as powerful as law—maybe more so—because it doesn't look like law.

Jack:

That's the point. In a post-state system, you need ways to coordinate without summoning a new capital city into being. Shared registers and cadences can do that. They let sovereignty stay distributed while still holding everyone in the same conversation.

Samuel:

If it works, it's elegant. But it also means you've moved from being a cultural tinkerer to being an architect of the order itself.

Jack (*with a faint smile*):

Maybe. But in a world like ours, the architecture has to be spoken before it can be built.

Samuel:

You know, what you're describing reminds me of Mises—consumer sovereignty. The idea that in a market, it's the buyers who ultimately decide the shape of production. But here, it's not goods—it's language.

Eliot:

Here we go.

Samuel:

My family actually knew Mises.

Eliot:

We know they did.

Samuel:

And he'd say that in the same way high-spending customers bend the market toward their preferences, high-powered users of language—people who can wield the word, the logos, with precision—bend reality toward their vision.

Jack:

Meaning the best speakers get to define the frame everyone else lives in.

Samuel:

Exactly. It's not fair in the playground sense, but it's inevitable. Whoever uses the language most effectively becomes the gravitational centre the rest orbit.

Eliot:

So in your model, it's not "the people" shaping the shared reality—it's the ones with the strongest grasp of the register.

Samuel:

That's my point. You can talk about distributed sovereignty all day, but in practice, the patterns will form around those who can work the cadences best.

Jack:

Which is why part of the project is training more people to do exactly that. If we don't, the gravitational centres won't be chosen—they'll just happen, and we'll all be living inside someone else's sentence.

Samuel:

Then the question is—who decides what's "good" use of language?

Jack:

Nobody. Or rather, everybody. The point isn't to fix a style—it's to make people aware that style is choice, that every sentence has an architecture, and they can build their own.

Eliot:

But you do see where this lands, right? You talk about distributed sovereignty, but if the gravitational pull always forms around the best speakers, we're basically back to an elite. A philological class.

Samuel:

More than that—a cognitive class. Not the aristocracy of birth, but of mind. And instead of land or titles, the currency's cadence and grammar.

Eliot:

Yeah. Swap out the cut-glass accent for the ability to hold a room in *Aristocratic English* and you've still built a ladder most people won't climb.

Jack:

Maybe. But here's the thing—it's easier to learn. Perfecting your grammar, your use of tense, your command of rhythm—that's a skill anyone can practice. You can't just wake up one morning and decide to have the King's English accent. That was gatekept by birth and schooling.

Samuel:

So in your model, the aristocracy's not hereditary—it's cultivated.

Jack:

Exactly. If you put in the time, you can rise in it. And because it's visible—audible—people can hear it and copy it. No boarding school required.

Eliot:

But you'd still have people who never bother.

Jack:

True. But that's the same with any art, or any craft. The point is, it's open. The tools aren't locked away in some London club—they're in the air, in the way we speak to each other.

Samuel:

And in that sense, it's meritocratic. The person with the most refined language shapes the frame—because they've earned the right to.

Jack:

Earned, yes—but also shared. The best of them will teach others, so the frame keeps widening instead of narrowing.

Eliot:

There's something I can't get past, Jack. In *The Auerom*, you had that story about the prophetic perfect—where a society was run on sentences that made the future sound like it had already happened.

Jack (*nodding*):

Right. "This will have been the moment." That tense folds time so you treat the outcome as inevitable.

Eliot:

Exactly. And in your story it was beautiful—people used it to focus the mind, to bind themselves to the better version of the day. But a tyrant could take the same structure and twist it. Hack a form of English so the whole society starts thinking their rule is inevitable.

Samuel:

That's linguistic tyranny. Change the register, change the reality—and lock everyone into it before they even notice.

Eliot:

Yeah. If someone controlled the dominant cadence, they could bend the shared frame so tight no one could speak outside it. You wouldn't need censorship. The language would do the policing for you.

Jack:

That danger's real. But it's not unique to what I'm building—it's true of any language. Every

political slogan, every national myth, every schoolbook carries some version of it. The only defence is to make people fluent in more than one register, so they can step outside whatever's trying to trap them.

Samuel:

So the antidote to linguistic tyranny is... linguistic sovereignty.

Jack:

Exactly. The more ways you know to speak a thought, the harder it is for someone to own it for you.

Eliot:

But you can see why I'm pressing this. If you succeed, you're not just giving people new words—you're giving them a new operating system. And operating systems can be hijacked.

Jack:

Which is why it has to be open source.

Samuel:

Open source, you said. You're borrowing that straight from the cypherpunks.

Jack:

Why not? Code is language. And language is code. If you treat it that way—shared, modifiable, forkable—you stop it being owned by one centre of power.

Eliot:

But language isn't just lines in a repo. People grow up inside it—it's wired in.

Samuel:

Chomsky would agree with that. He'd say we're born with a universal grammar, like an operating system baked into the brain. You can skin it however you want—French, English, High English—but the kernel's the same.

Jack:

Exactly. And just like software, you can tweak the interface, add modules, change the defaults. That's what register work is—new modules.

Eliot:

But if someone controls the updates, they control the whole system.

Jack:

Which is why it has to be distributed. No central authority saying "this is the correct form." Instead, communities fork it, remix it, pass it around. If Bamford's cadence differs from Sheffield's, that's fine—as long as people can still read each other's versions.

Samuel:

So linguistic freedom means not just freedom to say what you want, but freedom to reconfigure the language itself.

Jack:

Yes. The old states hated that—because if you can change the grammar, you can change the frame reality sits in. They wanted the frame fixed.

Eliot:

And now you're saying: make the frame editable.

Jack:

Exactly. Let people patch reality the way they'd patch code. A shared repo of expression that anyone can contribute to, and anyone can fork if they don't like the direction it's going.

Samuel:

That's elegant—if it works. The risk is that without a steward, it fragments too far and you lose the mutual intelligibility that makes it worth having.

Jack:

True. Which is why the work isn't just invention—it's translation. Making sure the forks can still talk to each other. That's how you keep sovereignty without losing the commons.

Eliot:

Here's what worries me. You open-source English and let every region fork it, and in twenty years you don't have one language—you've got a patchwork. Sheffield's cadence isn't just different from Bamford's, it's incomprehensible to someone in Devon.

Samuel:

That's not far-fetched. The country's already split in how it speaks. Give it a push and you could see whole regions sculpting the sound to their environment. Scotland might harden the consonants, draw in a Norse edge from old Orkney speech. Down south, where the air's soft and the wine's dear, you'd get a more lyrical French-inflected flow.

Eliot:

And up here in the north—industrial roots, heavy rhythms—you might see something more Germanic in its structure. Short, solid, machine-fit sentences.

Samuel:

Which means if a miner from Barnsley walks into a civic meeting in Kent, half of what he says lands like code from another operating system.

Jack Stone:

It could happen. But remember, shared cadences don't have to erase local colour—they just have to bridge it. You could have a Sheffield register that works for home use, and a broader, mutual register for cross-regional talk.

Eliot:

Like a trade language?

Jack:

Exactly. The old empires had them—Lingua Franca in the Mediterranean, Church Latin in Europe. But instead of enforcing one accent or one canon, you keep the core modular. Regions can bolt their own textures onto it without losing the ability to speak to the rest of the network.

Samuel:

That's the trick—balancing the strength of local identity against the risk of total fragmentation.

Jack:

It's the same with code forks. Too many and the project dies. But just enough, and you get innovation without breaking the build.

Eliot:

Except here, the "project" is reality itself.

Jack:

I don't think fragmentation has to be the end of the story. Look at Internet English—it's already a dozen dialects in one. Memes, gaming slang, corporate PR tone, text-speak, academic Twitter threads—half the people online slip between them without even noticing.

Eliot:

True. You can go from "LOL" to "therefore it follows" in the same thread.

Jack:

Exactly. And that's a kind of fluency no state ever planned for. People carry multiple registers in their heads now—switching on instinct. The danger isn't that you have lots of forms of English. The danger is if you lose the ability to move between them.

Samuel:

So the goal isn't one perfect form—it's training people to be polyglots inside a single language.

Jack:

Yes. Interchangeable, different, and beautiful. A northerner could speak in the clipped, heavy beats of an industrial cadence at home, then shift into a lyrical southern register when the conversation calls for it, and maybe drop into an aesthetic online form later that night. Each one tells a different truth.

Eliot:

So the art is in the switching.

Jack:

Right. It's like music—you don't have to pick one key for the whole song. If you know the transitions, you can play with tension, release, surprise. That's how language becomes not just communication, but craft.

Samuel:

And that craft—done well—becomes a kind of shared culture, even if the accents and cadences themselves are wildly different.

Jack:

Exactly. The bridges matter more than the borders.

Samuel:

Alright, let's make it real. If Bamford's the birthplace of High English—what does it sound like? Not just the idea, Jack. The sound.

Jack:

It'd carry the place in it. Slow, like the valley air. Words held just long enough that you hear the stone behind them. Not clipped like the south, not industrial like the north—something with room for the moor wind to pass through.

Eliot:

So... measured. Almost meditative.

Jack:

Measured, yes, but not heavy. Bamford's High English would keep its consonants clean, but soften the edges—no wasted syllables, no rush to the end of a sentence. Cadences would rise and fall in a way that lets the listener *sit* with each idea before the next arrives.

Samuel:

Like a well-laid path—you feel guided, but never pushed.

Jack:

Exactly. And there'd be a precision to it—not fussiness, but clarity. You'd hear the craft, but it wouldn't show off. In the same way this place builds dry stone walls—functional, beautiful, no mortar, but each piece placed exactly where it belongs.

Eliot:

Would it borrow from the old forms?

Jack:

Some. You'd hear traces of King James Bible cadence, but lighter. A touch of the Quaker plain style. And because we're here in the Peaks, you'd find local turns of phrase folded in, not polished out.

Samuel:

So the first dialect of High English isn't about purity—it's about holding the place in the voice.

Jack:

Yes. It's about speaking in a way that makes this valley present, even if you're on a stage in London. A dialect that carries its origin like a watermark.

Eliot:

And then, in twenty years, people will come here trying to copy it, the way tourists put on fake Scottish burrs.

Jack:

Maybe. But if we do it right, it won't just be an accent to mimic. It'll be a practice—something you have to live with to speak.

Jack:

Alright. *Picture this—not a translation from Standard English, but something born here.*

(He takes a breath, lets the pause hang just long enough to pull them in.)

Jack:

“This night is having been the stillness we shall yet remember.”

Eliot:

That's not... quite past, not quite future.

Jack:

Exactly. The tense sits forward and back at the same time. It tells you the meaning is fixed, even

though we're still in it. Bamford High English would use that a lot—this sense that the present is already part of your memory.

Samuel:

That's very Aureom. But the shape's cleaner.

Jack:

Cleaner, yes. And listen—

“The fire was in its quieting before the wind is carrying it forward.”

That's a doubled tense. First clause feels like the embers are already settling; second clause pushes the motion into the future *without breaking the moment*.

Eliot:

It bends time without making it sound like a riddle.

Jack:

That's the point. In Bamford High English, grammar doesn't just mark when something happens—it tells you what kind of *relationship* you have to that moment. Is it closing? Opening? Fixed? Still unfolding?

Samuel:

So it's not just a dialect—it's a temporal instrument.

Jack:

Yes. And because it's here in the Peaks, the register would be grounded—rooted phrases, long vowels, a patience in the delivery. But it's also hypermodern: it uses grammar like code, so you can nest timelines, layer moods, and still have it sound natural.

Eliot:

Natural to you, maybe. I think half the country would need subtitles.

Jack:

At first. But once you start hearing it, you realise it's just another way to point at the world—and in some ways, it points more exactly.

Jack:

Go on then, Samuel. Try it yourself. Take the line I just gave—“The fire was in its quieting before the wind is carrying it forward”—and see if you can shape it. Think about the grammar, the time-bending.

Samuel:

Alright. If the first clause is already in process, and the second clause pushes it onward, then the pattern is: *ongoing-past into assured-future*.

(He pauses, then speaks slowly, almost testing the code as he goes.)

“The valley was in its waiting while the dawn is in its breaking.”

Jack:

Good. You caught the hinge—“was in its” to “is in its.” That's the rhythm of Bamford.

Eliot:

Alright, let me try. Something less poetic, more grounded.

(He glances at the food pot simmering near the fire, then clears his throat, speaking with a rougher cadence.)

“The stew was in its thickening as the mouths are in their hungering.”

(Laughter ripples around the circle.)

Jack:

See? That works too. It doesn't have to be lofty—it can make the most ordinary moment feel charged.

Samuel:

So the rule is: take an act that's ongoing in the past, and bind it to a parallel act that's ongoing in the present or future. The hinge is the *was... in its / is... in its* frame.

Jack:

Yes. That's the Bamford structure. Past-in-motion meeting present-unfolding. It locks the moment as if it's already being remembered, while still living.

Eliot:

It's strange—it makes you feel the now more sharply, because you're already seeing it from the other side.

Jack:

Exactly. That's why I think of it as High English—it elevates the pitch of the ordinary. The stew, the dawn, even this fire—they become moments you step *into*, rather than just drift past.

Jack Stone:

What you're doing now—this is the act. Shaping cadence into form. Every sentence like this tweaks reality's lens.

Samuel:

Then let's formalise it. Rule one: the hinge of Bamford High English is the dual-temporal frame—was in its followed by is in its. Past in process, present or future in unfolding.

Jack:

Good. That gives us a spine.

Samuel:

Rule two: the subject is always concrete—fire, valley, stew, dawn. No abstractions. You ground it in the tangible, then let the grammar elevate it.

Eliot:

You're already turning it into a textbook, Samuel. That's not what this is.

Samuel:

If you don't codify it, it collapses into mush. You'll have a dozen half-formed versions floating around and none of them will carry weight.

Eliot:

Or you'll strangle it before it breathes. Language is a stream—it moves because it bends and splits. The moment you wall it in, you've killed it.

Jack:

Both of you are right. The grammar gives us an anchor. But if it ossifies, it stops being a register and becomes a law. Bamford High English has to live in the middle: rule-like enough to be recognisable, loose enough to keep shifting with the speaker.

Jack:

“The word was in its making while the meaning is in its flowing.”

Samuel:

Yes! That’s rule three: Bamford English works in pairs. A form in motion, tied to its echo. No isolated clause.

Eliot:

Alright then, Jack. You’ve given Bamford its cadence. But what about Sheffield? If this is going to spread, my city deserves its own dialect. Help me shape one—something... more romantic.

Jack:

Romantic Sheffield.

Eliot:

Steel and smoke on the outside, but under it—we’re a city of songs, of rivers, of stubborn hope. Give me a register that doesn’t just clang like a forge, but sings like a heart.

Jack:

Alright. Sheffield’s High English would keep its toughness, but stretch the vowels—give space for longing. Where Bamford binds the past-in-motion with the present-unfolding, Sheffield would pair the hard with the soft, the forged with the flowing.

Eliot:

Show me.

Jack:

“The steel was in its burning while the river is in its singing.”

Eliot:

“The steel was in its burning while the river is in its singing.” Yes. That feels right. Strong, but tender.

Samuel :

Rule one of Sheffield High English: pair the industrial with the romantic.

Eliot:

I’ll take that. Give me another, Jack.

Jack:

“The streets were in their labour while the lovers are in their walking.”

Eliot:

That’s it. That’s Sheffield. Work and love, grit and grace.

Jack:

Then you’ve got your dialect. Sheffield High English isn’t about time like Bamford’s—it’s about

tension, about binding contrasts. The hard and the soft, held in one breath. You should know—my version of High English isn't just Bamford's dialect. It's what I'd call the highest form. The cognitive elite. The very top register possible.

Eliot:

Elite? Sounds like you're back to Samuel's aristocracy again.

Jack:

Yes. But not of birth or wealth—of attention, of craft. It's something I built from years studying Tolkien's philology. Not the words, but the way he built a whole world into the cadence. Each sentence a structure, carrying history in its bones.

Samuel:

So you're saying Bamford is the experiment, Sheffield is the romance, but your *true* High English is for those who can bear the weight of its grammar.

Jack:

That's right. And now, I'm going to challenge you. All of you. Let's see if you can keep this fire-side talk alive—but not in Standard English. Speak only in your own High English, the dialect you feel belongs to you.

Eliot:

A test, then. Sheffield against Bamford against Jack's secret English.

Samuel:

And London will sit in judgment.

Jack:

Not judgment—practice. Think of it as trial by cadence. Each of us holds a dialect. Now we see if we can sustain meaning when the language itself is shifting under us. Alright then, let's talk about last night's rave. Let's see if you can hold it in High English.

(The audience chuckles; a few heads turn knowingly. Jack lets the silence stretch, then begins.)

Jack:

The night was in its surging even as the lights are in their burning. And I, in the pulse, was in my finding—her face among the crowd, her lips were in their waiting, and my kiss is in its remembering still.

(He glances toward a woman in the circle—Mara—who blushes, half-hiding her smile. Laughter ripples through the group.)

Eliot:

The bass was in its pounding while the hearts are in their trembling. And Sophie—aye, Sophie—was in her swaying while I was in my leaning. The moment was in its sparking though the kiss is in its breaking.

Samuel:

The floor was in its shaking while my steps are in their wandering. The crowd was in its pressing as my hours are in their vanishing. The night was in its holding even as I was in my losing.

Jack:

So it was: each of us in our weaving, each of us in our vanishing. The rave was in its storming while our selves are in their altering. And memory, even now, is in its binding of us to the night.

Sophie:

The crowd was in its rushing while our names are in their whispering. The music was in its swelling as my steps are in their slowing. For we are in our hiding, Eliot, while the eyes are in their watching.

Sophie:

That's why we don't go out much, Jack. Eliot's too bloody high-profile. Everywhere he goes, people are watching. It's easier for us to stay away.

(A pause. Then she looks directly at Jack, her tone playful but pointed.)

Sophie:

But tell me—what are the rules for *your* High English? You've got Bamford's grammar, Sheffield's romance. Yours is... different. Heavier. Where did you pull it from?

Jack:

Mine isn't made for ease. It's a discipline. I compiled it from three strands.

(He ticks them off with his fingers, like listing ingredients for an alchemy.)

Jack:

First, Aristocratic English—what I call the elevated register. Long vowels, deliberate cadences, words chosen for gravitas. It isn't about pomp, but about weight.

Second, Latin tense structures—the future perfect, the prophetic perfect. To speak in ways where what has not yet happened is already complete. It shapes the listener's sense of inevitability.

And third... Tolkien's Elvish. Not the words themselves, but the *form*. He built languages that carried entire histories inside their sounds. I studied how he did it, and I used those principles to braid memory and presence into English.

(The circle is utterly still now, the fire snapping in punctuation. Jack looks around, his voice measured and intimate.)

Jack:

So mine is less dialect, more architecture. A register not just to describe, but to command attention—maybe even reality itself. That's why I call it cognitive elite. It takes training, discipline, and reverence. Not everyone will want it, nor should they.

(Sophie tilts her head, half-curious, half-skeptical.)

Sophie:

Sounds closer to sorcery than speech.

Jack *(smiling faintly):*

All true language is sorcery. Some just hides it better.

(Jack reaches into his coat pocket, pulls out a worn page folded in four. He smooths it against his knee, the firelight catching the ink. The circle falls into a hush. He lifts his voice—calm, measured, almost ceremonial.)

The night was in its crowning even as the dawn is in its rising.
The silence was in its deepening while the word is in its binding.

The path was in its vanishing as the step is in its finding.
The kiss was in its sealing though the breath is in its breaking.

The fire was in its quieting while the wind is in its carrying.
And this moment was in its ending, even as its echo is in its living.

(The cadence is strange—at once foreign and familiar, as though it carries more time than it should. The syntax bends toward inevitability, the prophetic perfect shaping the ear. Around the fire, faces are lit in orange glow, some mouths slightly open, some brows furrowed in thought.)

Jack:

This is what I mean. Each line holds two times, two realities, one closing and one opening. It binds them together so the ear cannot leave without carrying them both. That is the power of High English. Not just speech, but architecture.

(Silence. Sophie exhales audibly, Eliot runs a hand through his hair, Samuel scribbles something quickly into his notebook. The circle feels heavy, elevated, as if the fire itself has been tuned into a different register.)

Jack:

Now it's your turn. High English isn't for ornament—it's for bending the world. Samuel, Eliot... I challenge you. Take your dialects. Speak as though what you say is not memory, not description, but reality itself. Bend us to it.

Samuel:

The valley was in its sheltering while the night is in its lengthening. The fire was in its keeping as the cold is in its fleeing. We were in our holding even as the danger is in its passing. The commune was in its building while the world is in its breaking.

(For a moment, the night feels steadier—the fire warmer, the valley closer, the circle tighter. The Bamford dialect bends everything into a sense of safety and endurance. Several listeners nod unconsciously, as if agreeing with a truth that has been made tangible.)

Jack:

Good. That is Bamford: time as shield, language as refuge.

(He turns, eyes alight, to Eliot.)

Jack:

Eliot. Sheffield. Let's see if you can make us feel your city.

(Eliot grins, nervous but emboldened by the challenge. He leans into the firelight, his voice softer than Samuel's, but carrying a romantic thrum.)

Eliot:

The steel was in its shining while the heart is in its opening. The street was in its labour though the song is in its rising. The smoke was in its veiling even as the kiss is in its keeping. And Sheffield was in its breaking while the dream is in its mending.

(A different hush falls—the hard-soft binding of Sheffield’s cadence. For a moment, the smoke from the fire feels sweeter, the labour of the day softened into tenderness. Someone in the circle sighs aloud, almost dreamily.)

Jack:

There. You see it? Samuel bends the night into endurance. Eliot bends it into longing. Both true, both real—and for the span of a few breaths, the world shifts to their cadence.

Jack Stone:

It’s not enough to bend the night. Bend *yourself*. Sovereignise it. Speak your own world as if no one else could. Not description, not memory—*reality by decree*. Make yourselves sovereign in language.

(A tense pause. Samuel’s jaw tightens. He exhales slowly, then begins, voice hard and deliberate, Bamford cadence anchoring him.)

Samuel:

My strategy was in its weaving as the board is in its clearing.
The commune was in its binding while the world is in its breaking.

I was in my planning even as the danger is in its fleeing.
And the future was in its bending while my hand is in its steadying.

Jack:

That’s it. Samuel sovereign. Language as command.

(He turns to Eliot, who has been listening intently, a furrow in his brow. Jack gestures, inviting.)

Jack:

Now you, Eliot. Claim your own world.

Eliot:

The steel was in its counting while the market is in its turning.
The bank was in its watching as the workers are in their earning.

The coin was in its fleeing though the trust is in its binding.
The city was in its breaking as the freedom is in its mending.

I was in my lending as the commune is in its keeping.
And Sheffield was in its rising while the world is in its reckoning.

Jack:

Good. That’s Sheffield in sovereignty. Labour and ledger woven as one.

Jack:

The word was in its shaping while the silence is in its yielding.
The tongue was in its binding as the thought is in its bending.

I was in my naming even as the world is in its forming.
And language was in its crowning while the people are in their dwelling.

The Auerom was in its sealing though the future is in its opening.
And I was in my speaking even as the city is in its listening.

Sophie:

Jack... you seem to be bending reality more than speaking it. I don't even know if I understood what you actually said just now—only that it felt like something shifted.

Jack:

I said, in simpler English: language is shaping us while silence is giving way; speech crowns thought, and people dwell in it. I named myself in the act of naming, as if the world itself were forming through words.

(He glances around the circle, then back to Sophie.)

Jack:

But that's the point of High English. It's not for easy understanding—it's for *feeling*. It shapes reality in cadence, not clarity. You don't just hear it—you live inside it.

(He leans back a little, eyes catching the firelight, and raises his voice again, slower, more deliberate, shaping another phrase. His gaze sweeps across the circle as he says it.)

"The beauty was in its gathering while the night is in its crowning.
The faces were in their shining even as the fire is in its hallowing.
And this circle was in its blessing while our seeing is in its weaving."

That's what I mean. Not description—creation. Not just words, but presence.

Samuel:

The fire was in its keeping while the night is in its holding.
The circle was in its gathering though the world is in its scattering.

I was in my thanking even as the company is in its giving.
And Jack was in his bringing while the thought is in its seeding.

And this was in its trial though the future is in its bending.

Samuel:

Now I see it. You weren't just spinning metaphors—you were showing us how to bend the air. To make presence out of cadence.

Samuel:

But here's the thing, Jack. If this works—and it does—then what stops it from being turned? From gratitude into obedience? From presence into command? Isn't this the very root of propaganda? What you call High English could bind people. But binding doesn't care if it's for beauty or for tyranny. A poet can bless a night... but a tyrant could sanctify obedience the same way.

Eliot:

Come on, Jack. Don't dress it in poetry. This is propaganda—just beautiful, lyrical propaganda. You bend people to feel what you say, not to think about it. There's no way around that.

Jack:

Yes, Eliot—if only one voice does it. If I stand above and declare, then it's propaganda, I won't deny it. But imagine if everyone did. Imagine if each of us sovereignised ourselves. Not a single cadence controlling the room—but a hundred cadences, a hundred realities, speaking into one another.

Jack:

When Samuel bends Bamford into refuge, you feel safer. When you bend Sheffield into dream, we feel longing. When I speak beauty into the circle, you see each other differently. If everybody can do this, then we live inside the very best versions of each other. My reality put onto you, yours onto me, until the room is thick with presence. That isn't propaganda. That's mutual sovereignty. A republic of language.

Samuel:

But Jack—look at the structure. You call it mutual sovereignty, but at scale? Those who master the cadence, those who wield it with precision—they rise. Always. That's not mutual, that's hierarchy. A cognitive class. Isn't language, by its nature, tilted toward those who command it best?

Jack:

And what's the aim of sovereign individualism, Samuel, if not for everybody to shape the world purely in their own image? Why should there be authorities telling us how we're allowed to speak, how we're allowed to think, what cadence is acceptable? Some will bend the word more powerfully than others. But that's always been true. What I'm saying is: open the field. No parliament to sanction speech, no academy to gatekeep grammar, no monarch's English. Just sovereign voices, each shaping their world. If some rise higher, it's because their reality resonates. Not because an institution crowned them. That's the core of it. High English isn't about control—it's about release. Not fewer realities, but more of them. Not propaganda, but plurality.

Eliot:

Plurality sounds noble, Jack. But you know as well as I do—it doesn't stay that way. Too many voices, and people seek the loudest, the clearest, the one that promises order. That's how cults are born. Look at Thorne. He wasn't even a philologist, and still people bent themselves around his words.

Samuel:

Then let's stop circling and test it properly. Jack, you've shown us beauty, gratitude, even constitution. But if you were to wield High English as power—if you were a leader, if you meant to command—how would you shape it? How would you write a piece of propaganda to make people follow?

Samuel:

After all, Goebbels was a philologist too. He bent cadence, imagery, repetition—made whole nations walk to ruin. If you claim this sovereignty, show us the edge of it.

Jack Stone:

The people were in their scattering while the city is in its falling.

The rulers were in their lying though the truth is in our speaking.

I was in my naming even as the order is in its breaking.

And you were in your following while the dawn is in its making.

This was in its crowning though the tyrants are in their fleeing.

And the nation was in its rising as the word is in its sealing.

The life was in its wandering while the meaning is in its crowning.

The hours were in their wasting though the word is in its keeping.

I was in my calling even as the world is in its emptying.
And you were in your following while the fire is in its binding.
Cast down your scatterings, lay down your fragments—
For the circle is in its sealing while your lives are in their giving.
The answer was in its keeping while the question is in its dying.
The doubt was in its fading though the command is in its crowning.
I was in my sealing even as the world is in its yielding.
And you are in your bending while the word is in its binding.
Only I am in the answer while your paths are in their ending.
And my speaking was in its final while your following is in its perfecting.
Therefore—every command is in its obeying.
Every breath is in its giving.
Every hand is in its serving.

Eliot:

God—do you hear yourself? That's the nightmare right there. If this *catches on*—if people actually learn to speak like that—it wouldn't even take a dictator. They'd tyrannise themselves. Bend their own lives into whatever command sounded the clearest.

Sophie:

It felt... inescapable. Like the words had already made the choice before I could think about it. If everyone had that cadence, how would we resist?

Samuel:

The danger isn't just a tyrant at the top—it's tyranny woven into the fabric. The cadence itself could compel. If this became the common tongue, society might march itself into chains without ever realising it.

Jack:

Or—depending on who speaks—it could make the world more beautiful. More spiritual. More poetic. A tyranny of grace, perhaps. A discipline of wonder. The language doesn't decide. The speaker does. Same tool, different hand. You can hammer, or you can carve.

Eliot:

Alright, Jack. Enough of crowns and chains. You've shown us the tyrant's tongue—now show us something else. Show us *beauty*. Pure beauty. Not power, not command. A world where the only reality you shape is one worth beholding. Can you?

Jack:

The storm was in its carrying across the sea while the cliffs are in their standing without movement. The water was in its lifting before the wind is in its bending of every tree. The sky was in its breaking, and yet the silence is in its returning once the thunder has spoken.

I was in my watching of it, even as the world is in its unmaking and remaking at once. You were in your breathing beside me, while the air is in its thickening as though every moment had weight. The wave was in its rising, and we already knew it was in its falling, though it had not yet touched the shore.

The light was in its piercing through the canopy, and the shadows are in their scattering though they seemed so certain a moment before. The stone was in its keeping of centuries while the moss is in its softening of time. The dawn was in its opening, even as the night is in its holding of what was.

And I was in my speaking of it now, while the stars are in their wheeling without end. The silence was in its deepening, and the infinite is in its stretching beyond measure. What we were in our seeing was more than we are in our saying, but still the language is in its shaping of what passes through us.

Sophie:

So... let me try. You said “the wave was in its rising, and we already knew it was in its falling though it hadn’t touched the shore.” In normal English that’s just... “the wave was rising, and we knew it would fall before it even hit the land.” Right?

Jack:

Exactly. But notice how the High English form holds the moment — not just the rise or the fall, but both. The inevitability and the presence at once. That’s what I mean when I say it shapes reality: it catches the whole gesture, not just a slice.

Eliot:

Fine, but how are you supposed to actually talk like that? A whole conversation? People don’t speak in riddles.

Jack:

You slip back, when you need to. This isn’t about replacing every word — it’s about lifting certain moments. Normal talk for most of life. High English when you want the world to tilt a little.

(He looks between them, the firelight throwing his expression into shadowed seriousness.)

Jack:

But let’s not just talk about it. Let’s try. An experiment. The three of us, right here, right now — a conversation in High English. About something ordinary. See if we can hold it, bend it, carry it. Pick something. Yesterday’s rave, tonight’s fire, or just the way the stars are in their wheeling above us. And then we speak it — not as it was, but as it *is* in its shaping.

Jack:

Alright, then. Let’s try this properly. A three-way dialogue in High English. Not just fragments — a conversation, sustained. But first—what should we use?

(He turns to the small circle of faces gathered. There’s a murmur of suggestions, half-serious, half-playful.)

Sophie:

Talk about the Test match — bend reality around cricket. See if your language can make that beautiful.

Daniel:

Or Thorne’s arrest. That’s closer to the bone, isn’t it? Try to shape the meaning of it.

Tara:

Or sovereignty. Post-state order. If High English is meant for big things, then give it a big thing.

(Jack glances at Samuel, raising his eyebrows as if to pass the responsibility on. Samuel straightens, folds his hands together, and speaks with his usual measured authority.)

Samuel:

We'll start with sovereignty. The others can come later, lighter or heavier. But if this experiment means anything, it has to show it can carry weight. Not a game of words around cricket, not gossip about Thorne. Sovereignty is the heart of what's breaking open now. So let's see if High English can bear it.

Jack:

Sovereignty it is. Then let us speak it — not in report, not in slogan — but in shaping. Three voices, one fire, one attempt to bend the present into speech.

Jack:

State was in its thinning though the people are in their rising.
Parliament was in its speaking but the street is in its shaping.
Sovereignty was in its writing on paper, yet the voice is in its leaving that paper behind.
I was in my seeing of it — the rule that is in its ending, even as the freedom is in its beginning.

Samuel:

Order was in its holding, but the fields are in their owning of themselves.
Law was in its carrying, though the hands are in their working without it. Sovereignty was in its claiming of crown and chamber, yet the fire is in its belonging to those who gather round it.
I was in my speaking of it now — the authority that is in its loosening, even as the commune is in its binding together.

Eliot:

Ledger was in its keeping though the people are in their trusting beyond coin.
Banks were in their measuring, but the market is in its unmaking by the crowd.
Sovereignty was in its centring in London, yet the north is in its holding of itself without asking leave.
I was in my saying of it — the city that is in its fading, even as the commune is in its shining like steel in morning.

Sophie:

It sounds... like you're not describing, but *declaring*. Like you're pulling a different world into being just by speaking it.

Jack:

That's the point. Sovereignty isn't just politics. It's in the saying.

Samuel:

Crown was in its holding but the people are in their shaping.
Sovereign was in his throne, though the ground is in its feeding us without his blessing.
Sovereignty is in its standing only where the commune is in its living.
I was in my speaking — the order that is in its ending, even as the commune is in its beginning.

Eliot:

Commune was in its binding, but the north is in its remembering itself.
Fields were in their greening, though the factory is in its shining with its own fire.

Sovereignty is in its bending southward, yet the steel is in its carrying of our own law.
I was in my saying — the people that are in their strength, even as London is in its forgetting.

Jack:

Parliament was in its speaking, but the language is in its holding of the true power.
King was in his naming, though the word is in its unmaking of kings.
Sovereignty is in its grammar, in its tense, in its cadence that is in its bending of minds.
I was in my speaking — the self that is in its sovereigning through the sentence, even as the world is in its remaking.

Samuel:

Then your sovereignty is in its isolation — a single voice sovereigning itself. That is not enough.

Eliot:

And mine is not in its isolation, but in the region that is in its lifting together. Sovereignty as steel, forged by many, not one.

Jack:

And yet both of yours are in their needing the word. Without the tongue, the sovereignty is in its silence. And silence is in its nothing.

Samuel:

Land was in its giving long before the law is in its writing.
Soil was in its feeding when the crown is in its taxing.
Sovereignty is in its circle, not in its throne.
I was in my speaking — the earth that is in its binding us, even as the city is in its breaking us apart.

Eliot:

Forge was in its blazing when the parliament is in its sleeping.
Steel was in its shaping of men while the south is in its forgetting of us.
Sovereignty is in its striking of hammer on anvil, not in its debating of empty halls.
I was in my saying — the north that is in its sovereigning, even as the south is in its faltering.

Jack:

Commune was in its forming, but the word is in its commanding.
People were in their shouting, though the grammar is in its guiding.
Sovereignty is in its cadence, in its shaping of thought, in its turning of silence to obedience.
I was in my speaking — the tongue that is in its sovereigning beyond land, beyond steel, beyond circle.

Samuel:

And yet without the circle, your word is in its vanishing. The voice that speaks alone is in its ending as soon as it begins.

Eliot:

Without the people, your tongue is in its hollowing. You sovereign nothing but your echo.

Jack:

Without the word, your people are in their silence. Without cadence, your sovereignty is in its blindness. The world is in its waiting to be shaped — and I am in my shaping of it now.

Jack:

Sovereignty is in its trembling.

Circle was in its holding, the steel was in its striking — but the word is in its binding of both.
Crown was in its vanishing, the parliament was in its thinning — yet the tongue is in its rising above them.

Sovereignty is in its bending to cadence, and the cadence is in its sovereigning now.

I was in my speaking — the world that is in its turning as I name it, even as you are in your hearing of it becoming.

Sophie:

Alright, enough. Before we all vanish into Jack's new world, let's bring it down a notch. If you want to prove High English works, why don't you all try it on something a little less... cosmic. Talk about cricket next. At least then I might keep up.

Jack:

Fair enough. Cricket it is.

Samuel:

The match was in its dragging through days, yet the final hour is in its quickening of all.

Bat was in its failing through the order, though Carter is in his standing at the crease.

The game was in its slipping toward India, yet the bowl is in its finding of the edge.

I was in my seeing — the crowd that is in its thundering, even as the sun was in its falling behind the stands.

Eliot:

Field was in its holding of breath, though Patel was in his flashing drives.

The ball was in its bruising of the pitch, though every stroke is in its echoing like steel on stone.

The day was in its bowing to the last over, yet the north is in its roaring as Mitchell is in his bending of fate.

I was in my saying — the crowd that is in its crying of joy, even as the shadows were in their stretching over Old Trafford.

Jack:

The test was in its measuring of endurance, though the game is in its collapsing to a single breath.

The bat was in its silence, the fielders in their circling — yet the word is in its naming of victory before the wicket is in its tumbling.

The nation was in its glancing — England in its holding, India in its striving — but the flow is in its bending all to this one strike.

I was in my speaking — the ball that is in its ending of the match, even as the crowd is in its living of it forever.

Sophie:

If you lot can make cricket sound like epic myth, I'd love to hear you try the weather. Come on, give us a forecast in High English.

Samuel:

The clouds were in their thickening this morning, though the valley is in its greening from the rain.

The wind was in its rushing across Bamford Edge, yet the stone is in its holding stillness.

The sovereignty of the weather is in its humbling of us — for we were in our coats, even as the sun is in its teasing of us now.

Eliot:

The sky was in its brooding when we left the city, though the moors are in their shining with sudden light.

The rain was in its drumming on the steel roofs, though the chimneys are in their steaming with it still.

The sovereignty of the day is in its shifting — grey in its power, blue in its promise — and Sheffield is in its taking both as its own.

Jack:

The weather was in its carrying of time — each cloud a sentence, each break of light a cadence.

The rain was in its naming of patience, though the sun is in its giving of sudden joy.

The sovereignty of the sky is in its grammar — storms in their commas, winds in their clauses, silence in its full stop.

I was in my speaking — the day that is in its composing itself around us, even as we are in our reading of it now.

Alright. Enough experiments for a moment. Tell me honestly — what do you all make of it? This way of speaking. The High English. Is it worth pushing further, or is it just smoke and mirrors around a campfire?

Samuel:

It has force. No denying that. It bends the air in a way normal English doesn't. But force can cut both ways. You can elevate, yes — or dominate. My worry is always: who gets to hold the cadence, and who is held by it?

Eliot:

I like it, though I'd never use it in normal life — not unless I wanted everybody to think I'd lost my mind. It works in here because we're listening for it. It draws people in. That's a strength. But it's also slippery. Half the time, I don't know whether I'm understanding it or just *feeling* it.

Sophie:

That's the point though, isn't it? You're not meant to just understand it — you're meant to feel it land. But I'll admit... it can feel like you're bending reality around us, Jack, and we're not always sure what's true and what's just cadence. It's powerful, but a bit... unnerving.

Jack:

That's fair. Maybe that's exactly the test — whether it frightens us, or frees us. You know, I should probably explain why philology matters to me in the first place. Philosophy asks what things mean in the abstract. Philology asks how meaning came to be. It's slower, closer to the ground. You trace the word, the sentence, the register — and in doing that, you start to see how entire worlds were carried in language.

I remember the first time I really felt it. I was about sixteen, and I stumbled on an old dictionary — the kind with etymologies at the back. I thought "hospital" was just a place where sick people go. Then I saw it meant *host*, *stranger*, *guest*. Suddenly, the building wasn't just bricks and beds, it was an ancient ritual of hospitality, duty, and care. That hit me harder than any philosophy textbook ever did.

That's the difference, for me. Philosophy builds castles of reason. Philology shows you that even a small word can be a cathedral. And once you've seen that — once you've felt how much power sits inside everyday speech — it's hard not to believe that language shapes reality more directly than law or politics ever could.

Jack:

And maybe that's why I'm here. Philosophy can give you arguments, but philology can give you tools. Tools that rewrite how we live together. Not just what we think, but the actual texture of life. That's the project. That's why I keep at it.

Eliot:

When I was younger, I thought philosophy was already niche — professors in tweed jackets arguing about whether a chair was really a chair. But now you, Jack... you've managed to find an even smaller corner and made it sound like the centre of everything. Philology. Who even studies that anymore?

Jack:

Not many, that's true. It went out of fashion over a century ago. Strange, when you think about it — Nietzsche started as a philologist. Tolkien was one, too, before he ever dreamt up Middle-earth. They both understood it: words don't just *describe* reality — they *make* it.

Take the Gospel of John: "In the beginning was the Word." That's not poetry for its own sake. It's saying language itself is the foundation. Existence spoken into being. Logos as architecture. That's what draws me in — every word we use carries centuries of sediment, but also has the power to strike new foundations if we learn how to wield it.

Eliot:

But hold on. Isn't that just philosophy by another name? You're still talking about meaning, truth, metaphysics. What makes your philology any different from the philosophers who chase those same ghosts?

Jack:

Philosophy asks what truth is. Philology asks how truth is *spoken*. That's the difference. Philosophy builds systems and categories — philology listens to the ground beneath the words, the shifts in cadence, the way a society's whole mood can tilt just because of a tense or a phrase. It's slower, more technical, but also more dangerous. Because once you learn to trace those roots, you realise how fragile "truth" really is.

Samuel:

But if it's that fragile, Jack, aren't you admitting that truth itself can be manipulated — even fabricated — by those who control the words? That's not just dangerous. That's power. And I think you know it.

Jack:

Take Newspeak in Orwell — that's the classic warning. Shrink the vocabulary, shrink the thought. That's not philosophy, that's philology weaponised. Orwell understood that if you alter the shape of a word, you alter what people can even imagine.

It's the same reason Tolkien poured decades into Elvish before he ever wrote *The Lord of the Rings*. He wasn't just making up sounds — he was building the skeleton of a world. The grammar, the

cadences, the tenses — they gave Middle-earth its weight, its reality. Without philology, it would just have been another fairy tale.

And Nietzsche — well, he started as a philologist before he became the mad prophet. His ear for language gave him those aphorisms, those sharp turns of phrase that bite even now. Imagine if he'd only been a philosopher — we'd be reading him like Kant: heavy, systematic, impossible. But instead, his philology made him musical, dangerous, unforgettable.

Eliot:

So what you're saying is, without philology, *The Lord of the Rings* might've ended up as a thousand-page treatise called *On the Phenomenology of Hobbits*.

Samuel:

Or *A Critique of Mordorian Reason*.

Eliot:

So if Tolkien had been a philosopher instead of a philologist, Middle-earth wouldn't have had elves and dwarves at all. It would've had, what — rival schools of thought debating in marble halls?

Samuel:

The Shire would be the Epicureans, living simply, drinking ale, avoiding politics. Gondor would be the Stoics — grim-faced, disciplined, obsessed with duty. Mordor, naturally, would be the Utilitarians, reducing everything to cold calculation.

Jack:

Exactly. That's the point. Philosophy tries to fix meaning into a system. Philology doesn't. Philology is about tracing what words meant *then* — what they carried for the people who spoke them, not just what they mean to us now. It listens backward. It's textured because it's layered.

If Tolkien had been only a philosopher, the story would be abstract — maybe clever, maybe rigorous. Because philosophy starts with ideas. Philology starts with words, with roots, with sound. Out of that comes myth, story, memory. It's why Middle-earth feels *alive and textured*. Every name carries the weight of a history. Every song is a shard of a forgotten tongue. You can feel time itself inside the language.

Philology studies the meaning of history itself, digs into the roots of words, the sediment of centuries. Tolkien did it better than anyone. He looked back into Anglo-Saxon fragments, old poems, half-forgotten sounds — and he pulled from them a mythology that England never quite had. His Elvish wasn't decoration; it was the foundation. It gave flesh to the myth because the words themselves carried time. That's what I tried with *The Aureom*. To root new meaning not only in the past, but in the present tense — to say: *this will have been the moment*. To give a grammar to lived experience so a community can feel itself as more than just transactions or chatter. In Bamford, in London, anywhere — the work is the same. Language is how you create a shared sense of time, of story. Without it, the commune is just bodies in a field. With it — it becomes a living myth.

Eliot:

So you're saying what Tolkien did for England, you're trying to do for... us? For the communes, for London, for Sheffield?

Jack:

Not in the same way. He gave a myth looking backwards. I'm trying to give one looking *now*. He pulled from history. I'm trying to build a grammar of presence. But the principle's the same. Without philology, it's all just description. With it, maybe we create something people can actually live inside.

Samuel:

But if you succeed, Jack — that's not just art. That's foundation. That's power. You wouldn't just be describing community; you'd be *inventing* it. You'd be telling people what their lives mean.

Tara:

Jack... I need to say something. You talk about philology like it's pure creation, and I understand that. Nietzsche and Tolkien—yes, they reshaped the world through words. And no one here loves *The Lord of the Rings* more than I do.

But I'm Jewish. And when you speak about language bending reality, I can't help but think of how that power was twisted. Goebbels was a philologist too. He knew the weight of words—their rhythm, their mythic pull. He turned a whole people's speech against itself.

(The circle is quiet; the only sound is the soft hiss of the coals.)

Tara:

So when you talk about High English, about crafting a grammar that can shape how people see the world, I just... I want to know you see that danger. That it can make beauty, yes, but it can also make obedience.

Jack:

You're right. I do see it. That's the shadow under every word. If language can sanctify, it can also curse. And maybe that's why this work has to stay human—spoken in firelight, not from podiums. The same power that heals can also wound.

Samuel:

So tell me, Jack. Have you thought about what comes *after The Aureom*? If you really mean to stand among the great philologists, you'll need more than one stroke. A high fantasy, perhaps — something in Tolkien's register. Or a work like Nietzsche's, a hammer to philosophy. Something to set the canon.

Jack:

I've thought about it, of course. Who wouldn't? But truthfully — I need a break. To live a little. Writing *The Aureom* nearly hollowed me out. And I'm not used to all this... (he gestures vaguely at the circle, the commune, the air of attention around him) ...celebrity. The book only just out now, and already it's more than I bargained for.

Eliot:

That's modesty talking. You know *The Aureom* will sell — maybe not in the way of cheap thrillers, but it'll find its audience. Enough to make you a name. Enough to keep you from walking into a pub unnoticed.

Jack:

And that's exactly what unsettles me. I've never wanted to be a banner, a symbol. I just wanted to

give people language. If *The Aureom* does sell, as you say, it'll carry me along whether I want it or not. Maybe that's good for the work. But for me? I don't know.

Samuel:

That's the price of founding a myth, Jack. Myths don't belong to their makers once they've left the page. They belong to the people who repeat them. If you're not ready for that, then perhaps you shouldn't have written it at all.

Jack:

Or perhaps I had no choice. If I'm honest, there are nights I wonder if all this — High English, *The Aureom* — is just vanity. Dressing ordinary feeling in grander grammar so it looks like philosophy. Sometimes I catch myself thinking it's nothing more than clever ornament.

Jack:

But then I remember Tolkien. Elvish began as a side project, a private indulgence really, and it became the seed of Middle-earth. He couldn't have imagined what it would grow into. And I think — maybe High English could be that for me. A beginning, not an end.

The truth is, I haven't thought that far ahead. I don't know what form it will take, or if it will last. Right now it's just an experiment, a way of giving shape to the present. But... (he exhales, half a laugh without mirth) ...if Elvish could carry a whole world, maybe High English could carry something too.

Eliot:

That doesn't sound like vanity to me. That sounds like someone stumbling into something bigger than he meant to.

Samuel:

Or someone building the foundation of a cathedral and pretending he's just stacking stones.

Samuel:

Enough hesitations, Jack. Vanity or not, you've built something. Don't leave it hanging in the air. If High English is to be more than a parlour trick, then give us a foundation. A piece we can work from. Show us what it really is.

Jack:

All right. A foundation, then. Not theory. A story.

(He pulls his battered notebook from his pocket, thumbs through a few folded pages, and then begins to read aloud. His voice steadies, takes on that cadenced edge again — half ordinary, half elevated.)

Jack:

I awoke at the first spill of dawn, the valley holding its breath in the quiet light. The stone walls of the longhouse caught a faint pink glow as the sun crept over the eastern ridges. In that moment, it felt as though the world was in its waiting even as the morning was in its breaking. Each breath was deep and slow, scented with pine and damp earth, and my heart responded by matching that rhythm.

Around the circle of fire the others stirred. We had gathered for the ritual of sunrise—empty of words until now—letting the stillness itself speak. The silence held us together as the first birds began their song. In that pause I thought of all the things we had yet to say.

When at last I spoke, it was barely above a whisper, but my voice carried the cadence of the valley itself. “The dawn was in its coming even as the last star was in its fading. The stone was in its enduring as the river is in its awakening. We are in our listening even as the world is in its forming.” For a moment the words hung between us like smoke. Then the elder nodded, and others began to add their own lines to the chant.

“The day was in its rising while the night is in its yielding. The river was in its gliding as the oak is in its blooming. We were in our gathering even as the valley is in its greeting.”

Each voice took up the pattern—was and is entwined—carrying the meaning through steady breath. We spoke of light catching dew on bracken, of stone walls holding our stories, of our history being woven into the path we walk. A child at the edge of the circle watched wide-eyed, as if seeing sunlight for the first time.

When it ended, we sat in silence, the transformation complete and yet just beginning. The ordinary stones and ashes of last night had become sacred by the act of naming. By speaking those words into the dawn, we had stretched this moment across time—part memory, part prophecy, wholly alive. I could feel something shift beneath the skin of the valley, as if the land itself leaned closer to listen.

After a time, an older woman—her face carved by a thousand seasons—smiled. “You spoke true, son,” she said softly. There was no ceremony in her voice, just warmth. “You have made the morning ours.”

I found my voice again, calm and steady. “It is given to us, and we in turn are its keepers. Each day the valley gives us beauty, and we carry it in our voices.” Her eyes glinted with tears of joy. “Then speak it into all the days ahead,” she urged.

I watched the sun rise higher, turning the moor grass to gold. In that moment I felt myself changed; the valley had made speech itself into something alive within me—each syllable a stone in the wall of the dawn, each line a step on the path. I knew I would never again speak with the clipped certainty of city air. My words now would always carry the valley’s slow, deep patience.

The morning unfolded around us in simple grace: we gathered bowls of porridge, pulled on woolen cloaks, and stepped outside to tend garden and flock. Every gesture felt quietly magnificent, ordinary tasks becoming part of the sunrise’s hymn. When a child tripped on a root, the laughter that followed was gentle and luminous, as if even joy here knew not to hurry.

Before the fire was fully cold, I took my turn in the morning reading. The passage I wove was not just any prayer, but verse born from our valley soil:

“The beauty was in its gathering while the mist is in its lifting. The faces were in their shining even as the sun is in its crowning. And this morning is in its blessing while our living is in its weaving.”

In each line I felt the valley echoing back. When I finished, the circle was silent, but breathing differently—heavier with meaning, lighter with hope.

Memory comes to me now: I recall the streets of London, a thousand unbreathing dawns and grey cobblestones, each day the same hurried promise that seldom came true. I remember how my throat felt, how every word I spoke there was choked by asphalt. Here, among these quiet hills and open faces, language has become something new: a living thing we share.

The afternoon light fell pale on our shoulders as we dispersed. I lingered by the river's curve, fingers trailing in the cold water. The current around the stone felt familiar—the flow I had always sought in my voice. Overhead, the sky was endless, and a lone hawk drifted high above.

“The river was in its singing even as my heart is in its settling,” I whispered, thinking of the chant. In that breath I recognised a completeness I had only glimpsed in dreams.

And so I continue: each day stepping into silence and speaking the valley. The world outside may change like weather, but here our beauty becomes ours in each naming. I have become nothing less than a conduit for the slow dawn of this place. And the story of our sunrise carries on, word by patient word.

Jack (hesitant, shrugging):

It's just a reflection of what I felt this morning. Nothing more.

Samuel:

No. Don't diminish it. What you've done — it carries weight. That's what I wanted you to bring into the communes. That chant of *was* and *is* — it folds time, gives the present both memory and prophecy. Do you realise the power in that? With such cadences, a leader could shape an entire people's sense of themselves.

Eliot:

Samuel's right. This is the stuff of propaganda, Jack. If words can make porridge feel like sacrament, imagine what they'd do in the hands of a tyrant.

Jack:

I won't deny the danger. But the point isn't tyranny. It's sovereignty. Philology roots us in the soil of our own speech. High English gives us cadence enough to make the world textured, alive. If a tyrant used it, yes, he could bend reality. But so could each of us. That's the difference. It's not a weapon for one — it's a grammar for all.

Samuel:

And yet you see the risk. Goebbels was a philologist too. He turned cadence into chains. What you've written tonight could be used the same way. Don't pretend otherwise.

Jack:

I don't. I know the risk. But what's the aim of sovereign individualism, Samuel, if not to give each of us the power to shape the world in our own tongue? Without authority. Without permission. The tyrant bends language for himself. I bend it so every man, every woman, can sovereignise their own speech.

Eliot:

Or so you hope. But power never stays evenly spread. High English might yet prove the sharpest blade in the armoury of control.

Sophie:

You know... whatever this is, however far it goes... tonight it just made me feel closer to all of you. Closer to this valley. Like the words held us here, together.

Eliot:

Closer than half the meetings we've had in Sheffield. Maybe that's worth more than all the theory.

Samuel:

Not everything has to scale, Jack. Sometimes it's enough that it works here, for us, now.

Jack:

Then maybe that's all High English needs to begin with. Not power. Not prophecy. Just presence.

They fall into silence. The circle breathes together. Sparks rise into the night, drifting like small stars. The valley holds them in its quiet, and for a while no one reaches for language at all.